Leadership Mindset Syllabus

High School

2026–2027

INSTRUCTOR INFORMATION

Instructor	Email	Room Location & Hours
Penny Burciaga	Penny@rivertech.me	The Café — Tuesdays, 11:05–11:45 AM

GENERAL INFORMATION

Course Summary

Leadership Mindset is grounded in Scripture and is a 35-week course that teaches students to lead from a fixed external standard (Scripture) and to reason with the models real organizations use. The first semester establishes twelve leadership principles shaping mindsets, each given a technical definition, anchored in Scripture, and demonstrated by a named biblical leader. The second semester introduces twenty-one mental models drawn from Toyota, military strategy, systems theory, behavioral economics, and value investing, each paired with the scriptural principle that governs its use. The two semesters answer two different questions: what standard governs this decision, and what tool structures the analysis.

Note: modifications may be made to accommodate school needs. Breadth and depth of content may be adjusted depending on demonstrated competency of learning objectives.

How the Course Is Taught

The course runs on a roughly 95% activity / 5% instruction model, consistent with the school's hands-on mission. In each 30-minute session a concept is framed in two to three minutes, students spend the bulk of the time performing it, and the learning is consolidated in a short debrief. Concepts are discovered through the activity rather than delivered before it; students hit a vague ask, a blown estimate, or a defensive reaction first, and name the principle afterward. Every session opens with two minutes on who applied last week's principle and what resulted, which is the primary retention mechanism available in a once-weekly format.

Why Principles Precede Models

Leadership content commonly teaches technique and assumes character will follow. This course reverses the order. Semester One is taught as behavior with observable repetitions rather than as values to be discussed, so a student is measured on whether the behavior was performed. Semester Two then supplies the analytical tools, and Week 19 states the distinction to students directly: a model is an instrument for judgment, not a substitute for it, and no model carries the authority the standard carries.

Biblical Integration

Scripture is integrated at the point of concept rather than appended as devotional framing, and is quoted from the NKJV. Every principle and every model carries a scriptural anchor and a named biblical leader who demonstrates it, so students learn the standard and the exemplar together. Models are taught for their mechanics rather than as endorsements of the leaders or companies associated with them, and this is stated to students directly in the bridge session.

Coverage

The curriculum is mapped against the full range of leadership competencies, so no core discipline is missed. Conflict receives four weeks because it carries nine sub-topics and is the one area where students reliably bring live material. Secondary skills, including public speaking mechanics, meeting facilitation, and written brevity, are addressed through embedded repetitions inside later units and the capstone defense, giving honest coverage without inflating the calendar. Two of the 35 weeks are protected as float to absorb schedule loss from other school activities.

Relationship to the Organizational Design & Management Course

Some students take the parallel Organizational Design & Management course, which builds a collective system: what happens when individually-led people must build a structure, culture, and management system together. This course is the individual counterpart, meaning the standard and the reasoning a person brings into any structure. Frameworks shared between the two, including root cause analysis, bottleneck identification, and retrospectives, function here as primary instruction and there as reinforcement in a new context. The course stands fully on its own.

COURSE MATERIALS

Required Materials

- A Bible — Scripture is quoted from the NKJV in class
- A notebook for weekly artifacts and objectives

ASSESSMENT

Assessment is performance-based and behavioral. Students are evaluated on observable conduct rather than on personal disclosure, and no reflection on feelings is graded. Artifacts include a structured request, a written conflict-resolution sequence, a root cause analysis, a pre-mortem, a constraint diagnosis, and a bias audit.

The capstone requires each student to present an unresolved problem from their own experience, name the principle that governs the decision and the model that structures the analysis, and defend both selections against challenge from the room. Students are assessed on whether the correct tool was selected and applied accurately, not on whether the problem was solved.

COURSE SCHEDULE

Course at a Glance

Unit — Mindsets & Models	Weeks	Focus
Foundations of Authority	1–3	Fixed standard, stewardship, servanthood, vision
Character & Capability	4–6	Integrity, competence, calibrated confidence

Unit — Mindsets & Models	Weeks	Focus
Execution	7–8	Structured requests, listening, estimation, backward planning
Courage, Compassion & Collaboration	9–11	Action under risk, attention, single-point ownership
Conflict	12–15	Initiation, self-audit, delivery, outcomes, restoration
Semester One Integration	16–18	Live case, assessment
Reasoning Models	19–26	Root cause, first principles, OODA, inversion, systems, constraints
Judgment & Allocation	27–30	Float, focus, competence limits, sufficiency, ruin
Evidence & Bias	31–34	Base rates, confirmation, survivorship, incentives, metrics
Capstone	35	Transfer defense

Learning Objectives by Area

Objectives are written as observable student outcomes and tagged with their level on Bloom's Taxonomy. Consistent with the activity-based model, most objectives sit at the Apply, Analyze, Evaluate, and Create levels; students demonstrate understanding by doing, deciding, and building rather than by recalling.

Area	Week(s)	Students will be able to understand and do ONE of the following
THE STANDARD		
Foundation & Authority	1	Explain why a leadership standard must be external to the leader in order to function as a constraint. [Understand] Analyze a decision in which a self-referenced standard was revised under pressure, and locate the point of revision. [Analyze] Distinguish stewardship from ownership in a scenario involving delegated authority and resources. [Analyze]
Servanthood	2	Distinguish authority exercised for the development of others from authority exercised for the leader's advantage. [Analyze] Perform a task the student's role would ordinarily exempt them from, and report the effect on the team. [Apply] Evaluate whether compliance in a given scenario would survive the removal of the leader's power to penalize. [Evaluate]
Vision	3	Write a future-state statement specific enough to reject a proposal against it. [Create] Convert an internally held goal into written form another student can act on without further explanation. [Create] Defend an assessment against majority disagreement on the basis of evidence rather than consensus. [Evaluate]
CHARACTER & CAPABILITY		
Character	4	Apply a consistent standard of conduct in a task where noncompliance carries no detectable penalty. [Apply] Report an accurate assessment in a situation where accuracy carries personal or relational cost. [Apply] Analyze the gap between an organization's stated values and its observable conduct. [Analyze]
Competence	5	Identify personal strengths and limitations against objective performance evidence rather than self-perception. [Analyze]

Area	Week(s)	Students will be able to understand and do ONE of the following
		Design a deliberate practice routine that raises performance rather than maintaining it. [Create] Distinguish deliberate practice from routine repetition in a given training plan. [Analyze]
Confidence	6	Receive a negative critique and restate it as information about a specific performance instance. [Apply] Evaluate a self-assessment for overconfidence or underconfidence against available evidence. [Evaluate] Explain how performing in order to establish worth distorts the reporting of performance data. [Understand]
INFLUENCE & EXECUTION		
Communication	7	Construct a request specifying the owner, the action, the deadline, and the completion condition. [Create] Restate an opposing position accurately enough that its holder accepts the restatement. [Apply] Assess a communication by the receiver's demonstrated understanding rather than by the sender's delivery. [Evaluate]
Commitment	8	Estimate the duration of a task, execute it, and analyze the gap between estimate and actual. [Analyze] Derive present-day action by sequencing backward from a fixed future deadline. [Create] Explain why underestimation persists even with direct prior experience of the same task. [Understand]
Courage	9	Initiate an action when preparation is objectively sufficient but subjective confidence has not caught up. [Apply] Analyze how the cost of an avoided conversation compounds as a function of delay. [Analyze] Evaluate whether a given risk is worth accepting against the objective and the probable cost. [Evaluate]
PEOPLE		
Compassion	10	Weigh situational explanations for another person's behavior before dispositional ones. [Analyze] Sustain undivided attention through a full conversation and assess the effect on the other party. [Evaluate] Infer emotional and relational state from indirect signals and adjust action accordingly. [Apply]
Collaboration	11	Assign single-point accountability for every deliverable in a team project. [Apply] Diagnose a failed group project for diffusion of responsibility and unassigned ownership. [Analyze] Map task interdependence so that one member's output is identified as another's required input. [Create]
CONFLICT		
Conflict Resolution	12–15	Initiate a resolution conversation upon becoming aware of a breach, regardless of which party is at fault. [Apply] Execute the escalation sequence in order: private, then witnessed, then institutional. [Apply] Identify and state one's own contribution to a dispute before addressing the other party's. [Analyze] Evaluate a one-sided account for premature adjudication and specify what information is missing. [Evaluate]

Area	Week(s)	Students will be able to understand and do ONE of the following
		Distinguish correction delivered for the recipient's benefit from criticism delivered for the confronter's vindication. [Analyze] Determine when to yield a defensible position, and justify the decision by relative value. [Evaluate] Restore a party to full standing after resolution, and explain why partial restoration resolves nothing. [Apply]
REASONING MODELS TO APPLY TO LEADERSHIP MINDSETS		
Models & Their Limits	19	Explain what a model omits, and why that omission is both its usefulness and its danger. [Understand] Distinguish a governing standard from an analytical tool in a given decision. [Analyze]
Causal Analysis	20	Trace an observed failure through iterative causal questioning to a process cause rather than a person. [Analyze] Diagnose a root cause analysis that terminated at blame, and correct it to a countermeasure. [Evaluate]
Structured Reasoning	21–24	Decompose a problem to independently verifiable premises and rebuild the conclusion from those alone. [Analyze] Reverse a goal into its failure conditions and eliminate them in priority order. [Create] Extend a proposed action to its second and third consequences, including other parties' reactions. [Analyze] Cycle observation, orientation, decision, and action under time pressure, and assess the effect of tempo. [Apply]
Systems & Constraints	25–26	Identify reinforcing and balancing loops in a system and locate the delay producing overcorrection. [Analyze] Locate the limiting constraint in a process and demonstrate why improvement elsewhere yields no gain. [Analyze] Propose a sequence to exploit, subordinate to, and elevate a constraint. [Create]
JUDGMENT & ALLOCATION		
Focus & Competence	28	Identify the minority of inputs producing the majority of a result and reallocate effort accordingly. [Apply] Locate the boundary of personal competence and justify declining a task that falls outside it. [Evaluate]
Sufficiency & Survival	29–30	Set an aspiration level and select the first alternative meeting it under a time constraint. [Apply] Size a buffer against error in the estimate itself rather than against environmental variance alone. [Create] Evaluate a favorable opportunity for exposure to irreversible loss and recommend eliminating that exposure. [Evaluate]
EVIDENCE & BIAS		
Probabilistic Judgment	31	Anchor a probability estimate on the base rate before adjusting for case-specific detail. [Apply] Explain why a vivid description increases estimation error rather than reducing it. [Understand] Apply an incompetence-before-malice prior and identify the evidence that would overturn it. [Analyze]
Evidence Discipline	32–33	State in advance what observable result would falsify a held position. [Create] Design a test capable of eliminating a hypothesis rather than confirming it. [Create] Identify the excluded population in a conclusion drawn from successes alone. [Analyze] Evaluate a continuation decision using prospective costs and benefits only. [Evaluate]

Area	Week(s)	Students will be able to understand and do ONE of the following
Incentives & Measurement	34	Examine a party's reward structure before evaluating that party's reasoning. [Analyze] Predict how a proposed metric will be optimized for once it becomes a target. [Evaluate]
TRANSFER		
Integration & Capstone	16–18, 35	Apply the full set of principles to one live case and defend the selection to the room. [Evaluate] Present an unresolved problem from personal experience, name the governing principle and the structuring model, and defend both against challenge. [Create] Distinguish problems that require a standard from problems that require a tool. [Analyze]